

GRE Vocabulary Notes: Group 13

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1. Affinity

Meaning: A natural liking, connection, or similarity.

Tip to remember: Affinity sounds like “a friend.” If you have affinity for something, you feel friendly toward it.

Sentence: He has a strong affinity for mathematics and engineering.

2. Altruistic

Meaning: Unselfish and concerned for the welfare of others.

Tip to remember: Think of “all true service.” An altruistic person truly helps others without expecting reward.

Sentence: Her altruistic decision to volunteer impressed everyone.

3. Baroque

Meaning: Highly ornate, elaborate, or excessively complicated.

Tip to remember: Think of a building with too many decorations and curves. That style is baroque.

Sentence: The palace had a baroque design with elaborate details.

4. Byzantine

Meaning: Extremely complicated and difficult to understand.

Tip to remember: Think of a confusing government office with many rules and steps. That system is byzantine.

Sentence: The university’s scholarship application process was byzantine.

5. Compromise

Meaning: To settle by mutual agreement; also, to weaken or put at risk.

Tip to remember: GRE trick: compromise can mean agreement, but also damage, as in “compromise security.”

Sentence: Sharing the password could compromise the system’s security.

6. Conciliatory

Meaning: Intended to calm anger and restore friendly relations.

Tip to remember: Think of “conciliation,” meaning peace-making. A conciliatory tone tries to make peace.

Sentence: The manager used a conciliatory tone to calm the angry workers.

7. **Countenance**
Meaning: Facial expression; also, to approve or tolerate.
Tip to remember: GRE trick: countenance can mean face, but as a verb it means allow or approve.
Sentence: The principal would not countenance cheating in exams.
8. **Covert**
Meaning: Secret or hidden.
Tip to remember: Covert sounds like “covered.” If something is covert, it is covered or hidden.
Sentence: The agency conducted a covert investigation.
9. **Credible**
Meaning: Believable or trustworthy.
Tip to remember: “Cred” means believe. Credible information can be believed.
Sentence: The researcher used credible sources in the paper.
10. **Diffuse**
Meaning: Spread out over a large area; wordy and unfocused.
Tip to remember: Think of perfume spreading through a room. It diffuses and becomes spread out.
Sentence: His essay was diffuse and lacked a clear argument.
11. **Documentary**
Meaning: Based on documents or factual records; also, a factual film.
Tip to remember: Documentary comes from document. It is based on recorded facts.
Sentence: The documentary evidence supported the historian’s claim.
12. **Exhaustive**
Meaning: Complete and thorough; covering everything.
Tip to remember: Think of a list so complete that it exhausts all possibilities.
Sentence: The professor gave an exhaustive explanation of the topic.
13. **Exhilarating**
Meaning: Very exciting and energizing.
Tip to remember: Think of the thrilling feeling after reaching a mountain peak. That is exhilarating.
Sentence: The trek through the Himalayas was exhilarating.
14. **Extraneous**
Meaning: Irrelevant or unnecessary.
Tip to remember: Extraneous sounds like “extra.” Extra information that is not needed is extraneous.
Sentence: Remove the extraneous details from your essay.
15. **Fervor**
Meaning: Intense passion or enthusiasm.

Tip to remember: Fervor sounds like “fever.” It is fever-like passion.
Sentence: She spoke with great fervor about environmental protection.

16. **Futile**

Meaning: Useless; having no chance of success.

Tip to remember: Think of trying to fill a bucket with a hole. The effort is futile.

Sentence: Arguing without evidence is usually futile.

17. **Illusory**

Meaning: Based on illusion; not real.

Tip to remember: Illusory comes from illusion. It looks real but is not.

Sentence: The apparent improvement was illusory because the data was incomplete.

18. **Invidious**

Meaning: Likely to cause resentment, jealousy, or unfair comparison.

Tip to remember: Invidious sounds like “envy.” An invidious comparison can create envy or resentment.

Sentence: The teacher avoided making invidious comparisons between students.

19. **Lethargic**

Meaning: Slow, tired, and lacking energy.

Tip to remember: Think of a person lying in bed all day with no energy. That person is lethargic.

Sentence: He felt lethargic after studying late into the night.

20. **Metaphorical**

Meaning: Figurative, not literal; using comparison to explain meaning.

Tip to remember: A metaphor says one thing is another, like “time is money.” Metaphorical means not literal.

Sentence: The phrase “a mountain of work” is metaphorical.

21. **Mimic**

Meaning: To imitate or copy someone or something.

Tip to remember: Think of a child copying a teacher’s voice. The child mimics the teacher.

Sentence: Some birds can mimic human sounds.

22. **Numinous**

Meaning: Having a mysterious, spiritual, or divine quality.

Tip to remember: Think of standing inside an ancient temple and feeling something holy and mysterious. That feeling is numinous.

Sentence: The quiet monastery had a numinous atmosphere.

23. **Obscure**

Meaning: Difficult to understand; not well known; to hide or make unclear.

Tip to remember: Obscure sounds like “not secure in meaning.” If the meaning is hidden, it is obscure.

Sentence: The author used obscure references that confused many readers.

24. **Overt**
Meaning: Open, obvious, and not hidden.
Tip to remember: Overt is the opposite of covert. Covert is hidden; overt is open.
Sentence: There was no overt sign of disagreement during the meeting.
25. **Pellucid**
Meaning: Very clear and easy to understand; transparent.
Tip to remember: Pellucid sounds like “lucid,” which means clear. Pellucid means extremely clear.
Sentence: Her pellucid explanation made the difficult theory simple.
26. **Perpetuate**
Meaning: To make something continue for a long time.
Tip to remember: Perpetuate sounds like “permanent.” It means to keep something going.
Sentence: Poor education can perpetuate poverty.
27. **Rational**
Meaning: Based on reason and logic.
Tip to remember: Rational sounds like “reason-able.” A rational decision is reasonable.
Sentence: A rational person considers evidence before making a decision.
28. **Scathing**
Meaning: Very harsh and severely critical.
Tip to remember: Scathing sounds like “scalding.” Scathing criticism burns emotionally.
Sentence: The reviewer wrote a scathing criticism of the poorly written book.
29. **Subtle**
Meaning: Delicate, not obvious, and requiring careful attention to notice.
Tip to remember: A subtle change is so small that only careful eyes notice it.
Sentence: There was a subtle difference between the two arguments.
30. **Superficial**
Meaning: Existing only on the surface; not deep or serious.
Tip to remember: “Superficial” contains “surface.” It means surface-level.
Sentence: His analysis was superficial and ignored the main causes.